



WHITE'S TREE FROG · *LITORIA CAERULEA*

The calm frog that can live sixteen years.

A complete, fact-checked printable manual: the vertical enclosure, a humidity cycle that dips instead of sitting high, the water that is safe to mist with, feeding by size and age, and the health pages that start with this species' signature risk, which is being fed too well.

INSIDE

- ✓ The vertical 18×18×24 setup, the gradient, and a chart of the humidity cycle
- ✓ Feeding by size and age, and the ridge test that catches obesity early
- ✓ Seven health pages: obesity, chytrid, red-leg, bone disease and more
- ✓ Fillable owner, vet and sitter sheets, and an outage plan

42 pages

Beginner

Print or tablet

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CONTENTS

What's inside

Every page is written to be used, not just read once.

GETTING STARTED

How to Use This Package	3
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SECTION 01 · PROFILE

Quick Profile & Cost Overview	4
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SECTION 02 · HOUSING & ENVIRONMENT

The Vertical Enclosure & Where It Goes	5
The Temperature Gradient & Heating	6
The Humidity Cycle That Dips	7
The Water That Is Safe to Mist With	8
Ultraviolet B (UVB) Light & the Day Length	9
Substrate, Plants & Furnishings	10
Cleaning Without Soap, and Household Chemicals	11

SECTION 03 · FEEDING

Feeding by Size & Age	12
Feeder Insects, Treats & Supplements	13
Body Condition: Reading the Tympanum Ridges	14

SECTION 04 · HANDLING & BEHAVIOR

Handling With Plain Water & No Soap	15
Shedding, Color, Calling & Normal Behavior	16
Common Mistakes & Enrichment	17

SECTION 05 · ARRIVAL & LIFE STAGES

Choosing a Frog, Quarantine & the Law	18
Group Housing by Size, Sexing & Breeding	19

SECTION 06 · HEALTH & COMMON ISSUES

Health Red Flags & Finding a Vet	20
Obesity, Fatty Eyes & Fatty Liver	21
Chytridiomycosis	22
Red-Leg Syndrome & Bacterial Infection	23
Metabolic Bone Disease & Vitamin A	24
Skin Injuries, Chemical Exposure & Dehydration	25
Impaction, Parasites & Shedding Problems	26

SECTION 07 · QUICK REFERENCE

Setup Checklist & Targets	27
Emergency & Quick Targets Card	28

SECTION 08 · OWNER TOOLS

Budget: Setup & Shopping List	29
Budget: Yearly Costs	30
First 30 Days	31
Symptom Quick Reference	32
Daily, Weekly & Seasonal Routine	33
Power Outages, Heat Waves, Travel & Transport	34
Pet-Sitter Sheet	35
Owner Log	36
Equipment & Vet Log	37

REFERENCE

Glossary, A to H	38
Glossary, I to Z	39
Sources	40
Where the Sources Disagree	41
Version History & About	42

START HERE

How to use this package

Three ways to get value from it, depending on where you are right now.

UNITS USED THROUGHOUT

Every temperature and size is given twice. Temperatures appear in degrees Fahrenheit (°F) with degrees Celsius (°C) beside them. Sizes appear in inches (in) with centimeters (cm) beside them. The one liquid measure is milliliters (mL), per liter of water. Humidity is a percentage (%) of the moisture the air could hold. Prices are in United States dollars.

If you haven't bought a frog yet

Read pages 4 through 11 in order before buying anything, then the feeding section. Two decisions are the expensive ones to get wrong: the enclosure on page 5, which has to be tall rather than long, and how many frogs you keep on page 19, because when two frogs differ in size, the bigger one may try to swallow the smaller. Settle both, then use the Budget and Shopping List on page 29 to buy once instead of twice.

If your frog is already home

Start with the Setup Checklist on page 27 to audit what you have. Then read page 8 before you next fill the mister, because untreated tap water and distilled water are both wrong for an animal that drinks and breathes through its skin. Then page 14: obesity is the most common problem in captive adults of this species, and the check takes seconds. If anything already looks wrong, go straight to Health Red Flags on page 20.

Print these first

- | | |
|--|---|
| ☐ Page 27: Setup Checklist & Targets | ☐ Page 35: Pet-Sitter Sheet |
| ☐ Page 28: Emergency & Quick Targets Card | ☐ Page 36: Owner Log |
| ☐ Page 32: Symptom Quick Reference | ☐ Page 37: Equipment & Vet Log |
| ☐ Page 33: Daily, Weekly & Seasonal Routine | ☐ Page 14: Body Condition |

WHY THIS PACKAGE EXISTS

The White's tree frog is sold as the easy frog, and next to most amphibians it is: calm, sturdy, and one of the few that tolerates being picked up. The trouble is that its easiness gets read as low maintenance. A frog that eats everything offered gets fed everything, advice to keep humidity high gets followed with an enclosure that never dries, and tap water goes into the mister because it is what comes out of the faucet. Each of those is a common way this species gets sick. Every figure here is cross-checked against the veterinary and scientific sources listed on page 40, and every temperature and dimension is given in both imperial and metric.

NOT A SUBSTITUTE FOR

A veterinarian who sees amphibians. This is a husbandry reference for day-to-day care, and anything urgent is a professional call, not a page in this book. Amphibian medicine has real limits, which puts most of the weight on getting the setup right, and it also means the vet you need is not the nearest one. Find one before you need one, and write the number on page 28.

Quick profile

Everything at a glance before you read the detail.

Scientific name	<i>Litoria caerulea</i> . Also called the dumpy tree frog or Australian green tree frog. It is also filed under the newer name <i>Ranoidea caerulea</i>
Native range	Northern and eastern Australia and southern New Guinea. Forest and woodland, and often around houses, where lit windows draw insects
Adult size	3 to 4.5 in (7 to 11 cm). Females run larger: about 4 in (10 cm) against a male's 3 in (7.5 cm)
Captive lifespan	About 16 years on average, with one recorded at 21 in human care. More conservative estimates are 10 to 15-plus. Plan on well over a decade
Activity	Nocturnal. Sleeps through the day tucked against cover and hunts in the evening
Diet	Live insects. Crickets as the staple, juveniles fed daily, adults 2 to 3 times a week. Page 12
Enclosure, one adult	18×18×24 in (46×46×61 cm), the 24 in being height. 24×18×24 in (61×46×61 cm) for two to four of a similar size
Temperature	Cool side 70 to 75°F (21 to 24°C), basking area 80 to 85°F (27 to 29°C), mid-70s°F (about 24°C) at night
Humidity	50 to 60% baseline, misted up to 70 to 80% once or twice a day, then allowed to fall. Page 7
Water	Dechlorinated tap or spring water. Never distilled or reverse-osmosis (RO) water. Page 8
UVB	UVB (ultraviolet B) is the band of ultraviolet light a frog uses to make vitamin D3. Recommended rather than required: a 5% UVB T5 HO tube, replaced every 6 to 8 months. T5 is the slim fluorescent kind, 5/8 inch across; HO, high output, is the tube format; the 5% rating is what keeps it gentle. Page 9
Signature risk	Obesity. Read it off the ridges above the eardrum, not the waistline. Page 14
Handling	Tolerated, unusually for a frog. Plain water on your hands, no soap, 5 to 15 minutes, about twice a week at most
Conservation status	Least Concern on the IUCN Red List, the global list of species at risk kept by the International Union for Conservation of Nature. Buy captive-bred

Cost overview

Initial setup

The frog is \$20 to \$60 for a standard animal, more for a blue or other designer color. Itemized, the setup with its first supplements comes to **\$295 to \$565**, and the terrarium is the biggest single line. With the frog and a first vet exam, plan on **\$365 to \$775**. Page 29 has every line.

Ongoing

Feeders, supplements, UVB tubes and water conditioner run **\$150 to \$245 a year**, about \$10 to \$25 a month, with substrate and a little electricity on top. An exam is \$50 to \$150, and an exotic emergency fee alone often starts around \$250 before any treatment.

THE NUMBER THAT SHOULD DRIVE THE DECISION

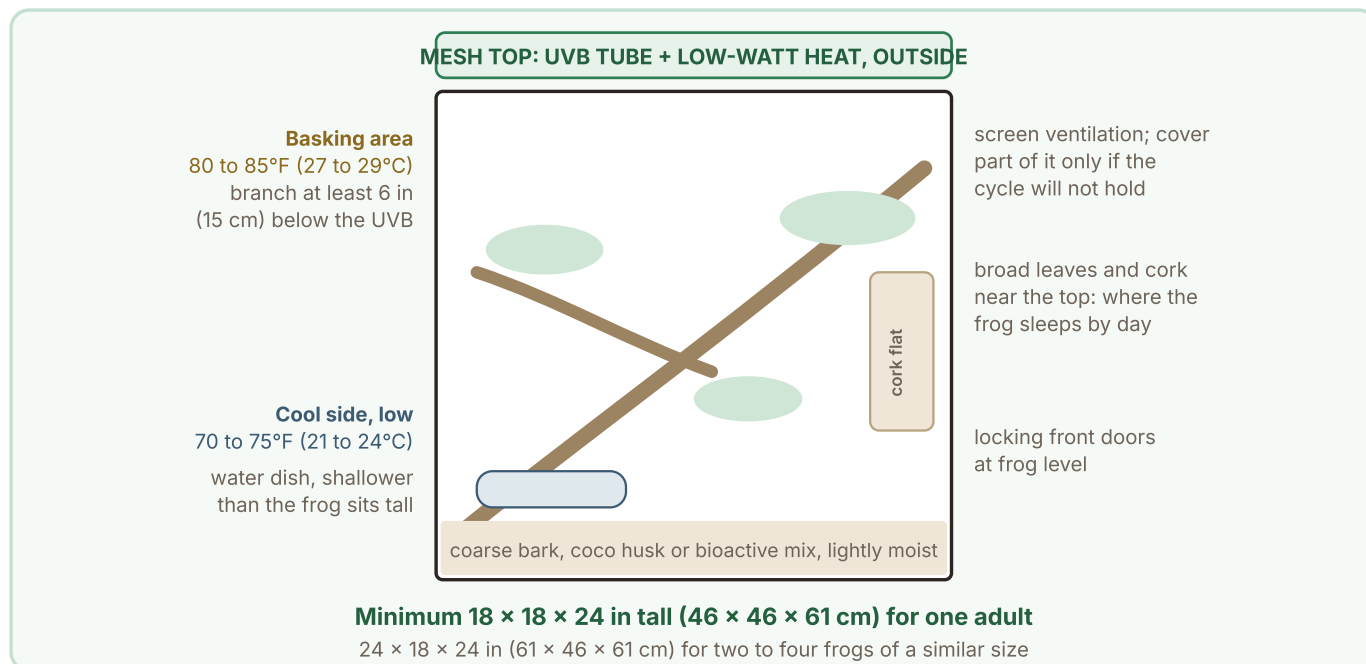
Not the price. The lifespan. A frog bought for a twelve-year-old is very likely still alive when that child is finishing college. The purchase is the cheap part of this animal, and the routine on page 33 is what you are actually signing up for.

The vertical enclosure & where it goes

An arboreal frog measures its home in height. The floor is where it goes to drink.

18×18×24 in (46×46×61 cm) is the standard minimum for one adult, with the 24 in as height, because this is a climbing species that spends its time off the ground. A 20-gallon tall tank is a smaller figure you will also see for one adult; this package uses 18×18×24 in. For a small group of two to four, all of a similar size, step up to **24×18×24 in (61×46×61 cm)**. A front-opening glass terrarium with a mesh top is the usual choice: the door lets you work at frog level, and the mesh is where the UVB and heat sit.

The lid has to fit and lock. Those toe pads climb glass without effort, and an escaped frog in a heated house dries out fast. Height only counts if it is furnished: sturdy branches, broad leaves and cork mounted high, so the frog can sit near the top, supported and out of sight.



Where the enclosure goes

PLACE	WHY
Out of direct sun	A glass box in a sunny window heats far past the basking target, and a frog cannot leave. The heat comes from a controlled source, never the window
Off a radiator, vent or drafty door	Each one swings the temperature and dries the air, which fights the humidity cycle on page 7
Not in the kitchen	Amphibians carry <i>Salmonella</i> with no sign of illness, and the hygiene rules on page 15 start with keeping them away from food
Away from cleaning and spraying	A frog absorbs what lands on its skin and in its water dish. Page 11

The temperature gradient & heating

A gentle, reliable gradient. Intense heat is not the goal with this species.

ZONE	°F	°C
Cool side, low in the enclosure	70 to 75	21 to 24
Basking area, high on one side	80 to 85	27 to 29
Night	mid-70s	about 24
Do not let the warm end pass	90	32
Act if anywhere falls below	65	18

The two bold lines are the limits for this species: a basking area that does not exceed 90°F (32°C) and a night that does not fall below 65°F (18°C). They are the edges, not targets.

Why gentle

A frog sets its own temperature by moving between warmer and cooler spots, so the gradient exists to give it a choice rather than to push heat into it. A frog that wants the warm branch will use it, and one that wants to cool down needs the low, cool side to go to. In most homes the room already supplies the cool side, and the only equipment needed is a small source that lifts one upper corner into the basking range.

The heat source

OPTION	HOW IT IS USED
Low-wattage basking bulb	A small bulb over the mesh at one side, outside the enclosure. A higher-wattage bulb overshoots the safe range in a box this size
Side-mounted heat mat	On the outside of one side wall, not under the floor, since this frog lives high up and the substrate holds water
Thermostat	Either source runs through one, so a hot room or a failed timer cannot cook the enclosure. Its probe goes where the frog actually sits, held with a probe clip or suction cup, never tape
Two readings	Digital, one high at the warm end and one low at the cool end, from a two-probe unit or a second thermometer. Analog dials drift, and one reading tells you nothing about a gradient

NEVER INSIDE THE ENCLOSURE

Every heat source sits outside the glass or on top of the mesh. A frog climbs everything, and a bulb, mat or heat rock it can reach is a burn. Its belly skin is thin and permeable, and a sluggish, cold frog does not move off a hot surface fast enough.

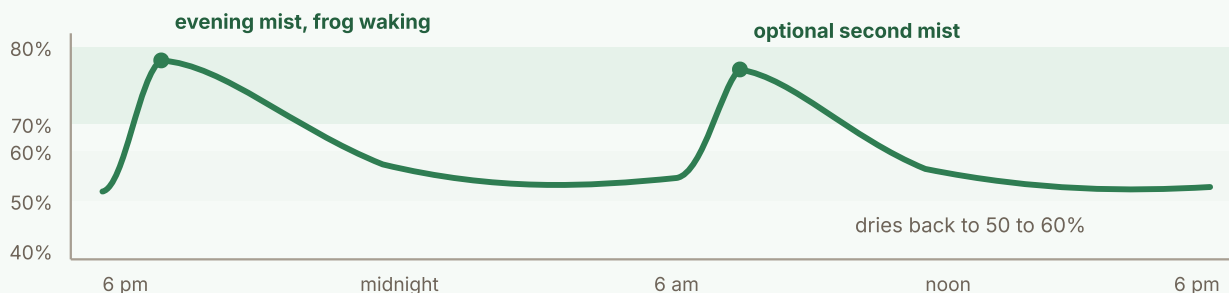
Signs the gradient is wrong

YOU NOTICE	CHECK
Frog sits in the water dish all the time	Too warm or too dry. Read the warm end and the hygrometer (humidity meter) before anything else
Warm end reads over 90°F (32°C)	Heat source too strong or the thermostat has failed. Turn it off, then find out which
Hyperactive or uncoordinated, then lethargic	Signs of overheating. Read the warm end now; past 90°F (32°C), turn the heat off, give fresh treated water at room temperature, and call the vet
Sluggish, not eating, for days	A cold room. Check the night low against 65°F (18°C)
Two thermometers side by side disagree by more than a degree or two	One has drifted. Replace it rather than averaging them

The humidity cycle that dips

The detail first-time keepers get backwards: too wet, all the time, causes more disease than a dip between mistings.

Hold a **baseline of 50 to 60%**, let misting push it to **70 to 80% once or twice a day**, and then let it fall back. Mist in the evening, when this nocturnal frog wakes up, so the spike arrives when it is active and drinking off the leaves. Constant, unbroken high humidity is directly linked to bacterial and red-leg problems, so resist the instinct to keep everything perpetually damp. The waxy coating on this frog's skin is part of why it tolerates drier air than most tree frogs.



The dip is the target. A flat line at 80% is the setup that breeds skin infection.

Holding the cycle in practice

- **Read it twice.** A digital hygrometer mid-height, away from where you spray. Read it an hour after the evening mist and again the next afternoon. Those two numbers are the cycle; a single reading whenever you walk past tells you almost nothing.
- **Mist the surfaces, not the frog.** Leaves, glass and cork, with dechlorinated water, until they bead.
- **Too dry between mistings?** Cover part of the mesh top, add live plants, or keep the substrate lightly damp. Change one thing, then wait two days to judge it.
- **Never dries?** Uncover mesh, mist less, and check the substrate is moist rather than soggy. Condensation all day, a sour smell or mold are the signs.

VENTILATION IS HALF OF HUMIDITY

Moist air that never moves is what bacteria want. Adequate ventilation for an amphibian is 1 to 2 fresh air changes an hour, which in a home terrarium means a mesh top or vents that are never fully sealed. Live plants help both ways: they hold humidity and they freshen the air.

The water that is safe to mist with

A frog drinks through its skin. Whatever is in the mister and the dish goes straight into the animal.

Use only **dechlorinated tap water or spring water**, for the dish and for misting. **Never distilled or reverse-osmosis water.** Distilled and RO water are usually not electrolyte-balanced, and without rebalancing they can be fatal to an amphibian. That sounds backwards, since purer water seems safer, but an animal that exchanges water and salts through its skin is not helped by water with nothing in it.

WATER	VERDICT	WHY
Tap, with a conditioner	USE	The practical default. Pick a conditioner that states it neutralizes both chlorine and chloramine
Bottled spring water	USE	Fine for the dish and the mister. Check the label says spring, not distilled
Tap, left standing	ONLY IF	Standing open for 24 to 48 hours lets chlorine leave. It does nothing to chloramine, which needs a conditioner such as sodium thiosulfate to split it. Unless you know your supply uses no chloramine, treat the water anyway
Fresh, untreated tap	NEVER	Chlorine and chloramine are fine for people and harmful to permeable skin
Distilled or RO	NEVER	Not electrolyte-balanced. Can be fatal without remineralizing

There is no published hardness target for this species. The rules with real backing are the ones above, plus water free of ammonia, pesticides and heavy metals. Treat the water before it goes in, not after.

The water dish

Wide enough for the frog to sit in and soak, and **shallower than the frog is tall when it sits with its legs folded**. Tree frogs are weak swimmers and a deep dish can drown one, a froglet especially. A heavy, smooth dish that will not tip is easiest to keep clean.

Empty, rinse and refill it every day, or every other day at the very least. The frog soaks and defecates in it, and a dish left to sit is the infection source behind bacterial and skin problems. Refill with treated water at room temperature, never straight from the faucet.

KEEP A JUG OF READY WATER

Treat a gallon jug at a time, label it, and use it for both the mister and the dish. It makes the right water the convenient water, and it is the water you will want on hand during a power outage, page 34. A dedicated spray bottle that has never held cleaner or plant food is part of the same habit.

A FROG LIVING IN ITS DISH IS TELLING YOU SOMETHING

Soaking is normal. A frog that sits in the water most of the day and night is usually too warm or too dry, so check the gradient on page 6 and the cycle on page 7. If both read right, it is a reason to look harder at the frog: page 20.

UVB, light & the day length

Not strictly required. The frog survives without it, and does better with it.

Low-level UVB is the recommendation for this species. It is nocturnal, so it never needed the strong lamps a basking lizard does, but a frog under working UVB makes its own vitamin D3, and vitamin D3 is how it uses the calcium in its food. Missing UVB is one of the two causes of metabolic bone disease, a condition frequently seen in captive amphibians. A gentle 5% tube is cheap insurance against it.

SETTING	NUMBER
Tube	5% UVB T5 HO tube: T5 is the slim fluorescent tube size and HO (high output) the tube format; the 5% rating, its UVB output, is what keeps it gentle. In a reflector fixture across the top
Distance	The basking branch at least 6 in (15 cm) below the fixture, and the tube within about 18 in (46 cm) of where the frog sits
Strength at the frog	An ultraviolet (UV) index (UVI), the standard scale for UVB strength, of roughly 0.7 to 1.6 where it basks, if you own an ultraviolet (UV) meter. Without one, the distance above is the control
Day length	12 hours on, 12 hours off , on a timer. A regular cycle matters more than the exact hour
Replace the tube	Every 6 to 8 months , on a schedule, whether or not it still lights
At night	Dark. A nocturnal frog needs no night light, and the room's own dim light is enough to see by

GLASS BLOCKS IT

Ordinary glass and most plastics filter out UVB, so a tube sitting on a glass lid, or a terrarium near a sunny window, delivers far less than it appears to. Mount the fixture over mesh. And a window is never the UVB source: through glass it is only a heat trap, and page 5 explains why that matters more.

The bulb that still glows

A T5 UVB tube keeps producing visible light long after its UVB output has dropped. That is why it is replaced on a date rather than when it looks tired, and why the date it went in belongs on the equipment log on page 37. A frog's schedule is shorter than the 6 to 12 months common for reptile tubes, so do not borrow a lizard keeper's schedule. A UV index meter is the only way to know the tube is at the right height and when to replace it; UV cards show total UV, not the UVB that makes vitamin D3.

UVB and the supplement jar are one decision

Whether the calcium dust needs to carry vitamin D3 depends on the lighting. A frog under a working tube makes its own; a frog without one does not, and needs calcium with D3. More is not better in the other direction either: an excess of vitamin A has been suggested to interfere with vitamin D metabolism, which is one reason to dose a multivitamin on schedule rather than generously.

KEEP THE LIGHT GENTLE

This is a frog that sleeps through the day against cover. Bright light with nowhere to get out of it is stress, not enrichment. The broad leaves and cork in the enclosure are what make a lit enclosure livable, and a frog that is always fully exposed under the tube needs more cover, not less light.

Substrate, plants & furnishings

The floor holds the humidity, and everything above it is where the frog actually lives.

Substrate

CHOICE	VERDICT	NOTES
Coarse orchid bark	GOOD	Large pieces hold moisture without packing down
Coco fiber or coco husk	GOOD	Holds humidity well. Keep it lightly moist, never soggy
Bioactive soil mix	GOOD	A planted, living floor. More work to set up, less to maintain
Sphagnum moss on top	ADD	A layer over any of the above helps hold the humidity cycle
Paper towel	SIMPLE	Easiest to clean and to check droppings on, harder to hold humidity. Good for quarantine
Fine, loose substrate, small gravel, small bark	NEVER	Easy to swallow along with an insect. Page 26
Cedar or pine mulch	NEVER	Toxic to amphibians

Soil is replaced when it starts to smell or stays waterlogged, because wet, dirty substrate is what builds ammonia. Bark and moss can be taken out and washed as needed, and the more often the better.

Plants

Dense, layered planting is the one enrichment item with real evidence behind it: in the closest study, tree frogs given plant cover grew larger and faster and chose the planted side. Use broad-leaved plants sturdy enough to hold a heavy frog. **Live plants must be free of fertilizer and pesticide residue**, on the leaves and in the soil, which means rinsing new plants and repotting them; keeping them in small pots makes cleaning easier. Artificial plants fill the dense parts cheaply and wipe clean, but they do not hold humidity or freshen the air the way live ones do. A mix is the sensible answer.

Furnishings

- **Sturdy branches and cork.** This is a stocky frog, and anything it climbs has to take its weight without sagging or shifting.
- **Broad perches near the top.** Wide leaves, flat branches and cork flats rather than thin stems, at several heights, with the best spots high up.
- **A daytime sleeping spot.** A large piece of bark set diagonally a couple of inches from the back wall lets the frog tuck in behind it to sleep. Dark paper on the outside of the back glass adds a dim, secluded wall.
- **The water dish,** low and stable, from page 8.

THE VISIBILITY TEST

If the frog is always immediately visible, there is not enough in there. A well-furnished enclosure is one where you sometimes have to look for it.

A FROG RUBBING ITS NOSE ON THE GLASS

Some frogs push along the bottom of the glass trying to get out, and a nose rubbed raw is an open door for infection, covered on page 25. A strip of paper a couple of inches tall around the outside base of the glass often stops it.

Cleaning without soap, and household chemicals

A frog's skin absorbs what touches it, and the water dish collects whatever lands in it.

The cleaning routine

WHEN	WHAT
Daily	Spot clean: wipe droppings off leaves, branches and glass. Pull uneaten insects within a few hours of feeding. Empty, rinse and refill the water dish, or every other day at the very least
As needed	Take out bark and moss and wash them, the more often the better. Change paper towel lining often
When it smells	Replace soil when it starts to smell or stays waterlogged

PLAIN HOT WATER, NOT SOAP

Clean with plain hot water. Soaps and disinfectants can leave a residue the frog absorbs through its skin. When something genuinely needs disinfecting, rinse it very well and dry it completely before it goes back. Refill the dish with treated water, never fresh tap water.

When disinfecting is the right call

After an illness, before reusing a quarantine setup, or when an enclosure comes to you secondhand. Use plain, unscented household bleach (not splashless or scented) at **30 mL per liter of water** (about 2 tablespoons per quart), left in contact for **at least 30 minutes**, then rinsed thoroughly and dried completely. Do it with the frog in another room, and let the item air out until no smell is left.

Household chemicals and scents

HAZARD	WHAT TO DO
Phenol cleaners , and formaldehyde and other aldehydes	Highly toxic to amphibians. Keep them out of the frog's room entirely
Other disinfectants: iodine, chlorhexidine, quaternary ammonium, chlorine, ammonia	Most disinfectants harm amphibians. None of them goes on anything the frog touches unless it is rinsed and dried afterward
Air fresheners, sprays and fumes	Ventilate the room whenever anything has to be sprayed nearby. The fumes are part of the hazard
Pesticides , including bug sprays and flea treatments	Toxic to amphibians. Never in the frog's room, and never on a plant going into the enclosure
Cigarette smoke	Listed among the toxins that harm amphibians. Not in the frog's room
Lotion, sanitizer, soap on your hands	The handling rules on page 15

Where you wash it

Not the kitchen sink, and not a bathtub people use. Amphibians carry *Salmonella* without looking sick, and the bacteria travel on the dish, the decor and the water. A utility sink or a plastic tub kept only for the frog is the right place. If a bathtub has to be used, clean it thoroughly afterward. Wash your own hands with soap and running water when you finish, away from the frog.

KEEP A FROG-ONLY KIT

A spray bottle, a sponge, a dish brush, paper towels and a jug of treated water, kept apart from household cleaning supplies. Nothing in it is ever used with a cleaner, so nothing in it can carry residue back.

SECTION 03 · FEEDING

Feeding by size & age

A sedentary frog with an appetite that does not switch off. Overfeeding is the default unless someone watches its shape.

Two facts about this species meet at the food dish. It spends most of the day sitting still, and it eats whatever is put in front of it. Put those together and a well-meaning keeper produces an overweight frog without ever feeling they overdid it. So the schedule below is a starting point, and the frog's body condition on page 14 is what corrects it.

STAGE	HOW OFTEN	WHAT AND HOW MUCH	DUSTING
Froglet , up to about 1.6 in (4 cm)	Daily	One to four pinhead crickets	Twice a week
Growing juvenile	Daily	Crickets sized to the frog, a few at a sitting	Twice a week
Smaller adult , under about 3 in (7.5 cm)	2 to 3 times a week	2 to 4 insects, crickets about three to four weeks old	Once a week
Adult , over 3 in (7.5 cm)	2 to 3 times a week	3 to 4 insects, a few larger crickets	Once a week

Larger items, an earthworm or a fuzzy mouse, come no more than once a month for an adult. Waxworms and superworms are once a week at most.

How a feeding works

- **Evening.** This frog wakes and hunts after dark, so feed in the evening, around the time of the main misting.
- **Loose or from forceps.** Insects can go loose into the enclosure or be offered from blunt, round-tipped forceps, whichever the frog responds to. Forceps let you count exactly what each frog ate, which matters in a group.
- **Prey it can find at its level.** Insects that climb the planting suit it better than ones that vanish into the substrate. Releasing them into cover rather than presenting them is also enrichment.
- **Clear up.** Pull any insects still loose a few hours later, before they drown in the water dish or scatter into the planting.
- **Never free-feed.** A bowl of insects left in permanently is how this species gets fat.

THE AMOUNT MATTERS MORE THAN THE INTERVAL

Whether an adult eats on Monday and Thursday or Tuesday and Saturday makes little difference. Whether it gets four crickets or ten makes a great deal. Write the counts on the owner log on page 36 for the first couple of months, and compare them against the ridge test.

A FROG THAT STOPS EATING

Check the temperature and humidity first, since a cold or badly set up frog eats less. If they read right and the frog still refuses food, treat it as a health sign, not a preference: loss of appetite is among the first signs of both chytrid and red-leg. Page 20.

Feeder insects, treats & supplements

Crickets carry the diet. Everything rich is counted, not reached for.

FOOD	TIER	NOTES
Crickets	STAPLE	The base of the diet, sized to the frog. Gut-loaded and dusted
Dubia roaches	STAPLE	A common staple in their own right
Moths, beetles, other cockroaches, grasshoppers	VARIETY	Good for breadth. Bought from a feeder supplier, never caught outside
Black soldier fly larvae	VARIETY	An adult food alongside crickets and roaches
Earthworms	OCCASIONAL	A large one counts as a big meal: once a month at most for an adult
Waxworms, superworms	TREAT	Fatty. Once a week at most, and less for a frog already carrying weight
Pinkie or fuzzy mouse	RARE	A fully grown adult may take one. Nothing about the diet requires it. Once a month at most
Insects caught outdoors	NEVER	No way to know what pesticide they met, and pesticides are toxic to amphibians
Anything too large	NEVER	An oversized meal can overload the stomach. Page 26

Supplements: two jobs, not one

An unfed cricket delivers very little, and an unsupplemented cricket carries about 1 part calcium to 9 parts phosphorus. Fixing that takes two separate steps, and neither replaces the other.

STEP	HOW
Gut-load	Feed the insects a calcium-rich gut-load for 24 to 72 hours before they go to the frog, 48 hours being the figure most often given. Feed them out within a few hours of taking them off the food, before they empty their guts
Dust, adult	Calcium and a multivitamin about once a week
Dust, juvenile	Calcium and a multivitamin about twice a week
D3 or not	Under working UVB the frog makes its own vitamin D3. Without UVB, the calcium needs to carry D3. Page 9

Dust immediately before feeding, not in advance: powder falls off, and an insect left sitting in a dusted container grooms most of it away. Shake the insects in a bag or cup with a pinch of powder until they look lightly floured, not caked.

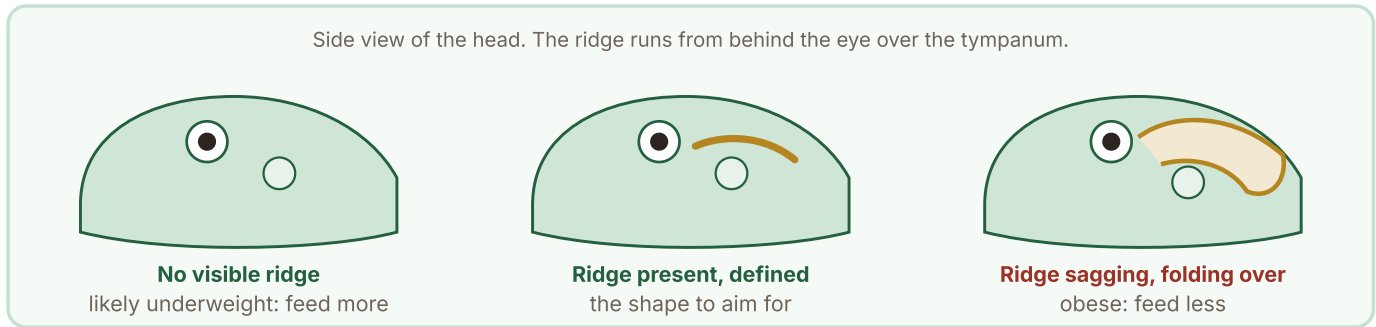
WHY THE MULTIVITAMIN MATTERS FOR A FROG

Amphibians cannot make their own carotenoids, the yellow, orange and red pigments found in plants and insects, so these have to come in through the diet, and vitamin and mineral supplementation is necessary to prevent nutritional disease. Vitamin A deficiency in particular shows up as a frog that can no longer catch prey with its tongue.

Body condition: reading the tympanum ridges

This species is round by design. Obesity is read off the head, not the waistline.

White's tree frogs are nicknamed dumpy tree frogs for their round, waxy-skinned build, and a moderate fat roll over the shoulders is normal for the species. So general roundness tells you very little. What tells you something is the ridge of fat that sits just above the **tympanum**, the round external eardrum behind each eye, and fat building in the armpits.



The ridge test, three readings

WHAT YOU SEE	READING	WHAT TO DO
No visible ridges above the eardrum	Likely underweight	Feed more, or feed more often. Check the frog is actually eating what goes in
Ridges present and defined	Right	Keep the current schedule and keep checking
Ridges prominent, sagging or folding over , fat bulging over the tympanum and in the armpits	Obese	Feed less: fewer insects per sitting, fatty items cut out, and more room and reason to climb.

When it is past a diet fix

In an overweight frog the excess fat starts to show clinically: a **cloudy look to the eyes** from lipid deposits in the cornea, a body cavity that looks enlarged from fat laid down inside it, and fat in the crests above the eyes heavy enough to interfere with vision. Any of those is a vet visit, not just a smaller dinner, because sustained obesity raises the risk of fatty liver disease.

MAKE IT A MONTHLY HABIT

Once a month, look at the head from the side in good light, take a photo from the same angle, and note the reading on the owner log on page 36. If you own a kitchen scale that reads in grams, weigh the frog in a small lidded tub at the same time. A series of photos makes a slow change visible in a way no single look at the frog does.

Handling with plain water & no soap

The risk runs the direction people do not expect: not the frog hurting you, but you hurting the frog.

This is one of the few frogs that tolerates being picked up, and most White's tree frogs handle well once they are used to it, more so than the great majority of pet frogs and toads. What makes technique matter is the skin. Amphibian skin is permeable and absorbs what it touches, including oils, lotions, soap residue and chemicals from your hands. Even the natural oils and salts on clean human skin can damage it.

The technique

STEP	HOW
Hands	Wash thoroughly with plain water only, no soap , immediately before handling, and rinse well so no lotion, sanitizer or soap remains
Or gloves	Powder-free vinyl gloves (nitrile is a second choice), never latex, wetted with dechlorinated water . After lotion, cleaning chemicals or a manicure, gloves are the safer choice however well you have washed. Deaths have been reported in tadpoles exposed to latex, nitrile and, to a lesser extent, vinyl, so vinyl is the cautious choice for a froglet
Pick-up	Let the frog walk onto a flat, wet hand rather than grabbing it, and support its body. Sit low, over something soft, in case it jumps
Session	Roughly 5 to 15 minutes , and no more than about twice a week
Afterward	Back into the enclosure, then wash your hands with soap and running water , away from the frog

First-timer mistakes

- Handling with lotioned or chemical-exposed hands. By far the most common and most damaging mistake.
- Handling too often, which adds stress even to a tolerant species.
- Wetting hands or gloves with tap water straight from the faucet instead of treated water.
- Treating handling as enrichment. For an amphibian it mostly is not; it is something the frog tolerates.

SALMONELLA, AND CHILDREN UNDER 5

Healthy-looking amphibians carry *Salmonella* in the gut with no sign of illness, and it spreads hands and surfaces to mouth rather than by bites. Wash with soap and running water after touching the frog, its water or anything in the enclosure. Keep the frog and its equipment out of the kitchen. **Children younger than 5 should not handle the frog or touch its enclosure at all**, since they are the most likely to become seriously ill. Older children are supervised and wash every time.

WHAT TO EXPECT

A sedentary animal, so do not expect a lot of movement during a session. This is a calm, low-drama frog by amphibian standards. A frog that struggles or leaps away every time is asking for shorter sessions or a break, and a new frog gets none at all until it is through quarantine on page 18.

Shedding, color, calling & normal behavior

Most of what worries a new owner is normal. This page sorts the normal from the worth-a-look.

Skin shedding you will rarely see

A White's tree frog sheds the whole outer layer of its skin on a regular cycle, and at room temperature that cycle is short: about **every 2 days at 73 to 91°F (23 to 33°C)** and every 3 to 4 days in cooler conditions. The frog pulls the skin off and eats it as it comes away, so a keeper rarely sees a shed happen and almost never finds shed skin lying in the enclosure. Shedding also does a job: it is one of the ways a frog clears microbes from its skin.

Color

A normal White's tree frog ranges from light blue-green through emerald to almost gray, often with scattered white or gold spots along the sides, and it can change shade somewhat. Its green is blue pigment under a yellow layer, and where that yellow layer is thin the frog looks blue. That is also why the species was named *caerulea*, blue: the first specimens shipped to England in 1790 had turned blue in preservative.

Calling, sleeping and sitting still

Males call, and call through the year, so a frog heard calling is a male. The species is nocturnal: it sleeps through the day pressed against cover, often tucked behind bark or leaves, and wakes in the evening to hunt. Long stretches of sitting in one place are normal for an animal this sedentary. In the wild, in the dry season, these frogs coat themselves in a secreted cocoon that holds moisture in.

Normal, or worth a look

NORMAL	WORTH A LOOK
Never finding shed skin	Shed skin lying uneaten: a sick frog loses its appetite and stops eating its slough
Shedding every few days	Shedding far more often than usual, or patches of skin coming away: heavier chytrid infections go with faster sloughing. Page 22
A darker or paler shade from day to day	Brown to red discoloration, or redness on the belly and legs. Page 23
Sleeping all day, high up against cover	Sitting on the floor or in the dish day and night, or unable to turn itself upright
Soaking in the dish now and then	Never leaving the dish: check heat and humidity. Page 8
A moderate fat roll over the shoulders	Fat folding over the eardrum ridges. Page 14
Calling at night (males)	Pushing its nose along the glass again and again. Page 25

A QUICK LOOK AT FEEDING TIME

Evening feeding is the best health check you have, because it is when the frog is awake and moving. Clear eyes, a good grip, a quick strike at the insect, and smooth skin with no red flush: that takes ten seconds to see and catches most of the problems in Section 06 early.

Common mistakes & enrichment

A sedentary frog is not an indifferent one, and the evidence here is better than for most amphibians.

The ten mistakes that make this frog sick

MISTAKE	THE FIX
Humidity held high around the clock	A cycle with a dry-back to 50 to 60%. Page 7
Untreated tap, distilled or RO water in the mister	Dechlorinated tap or spring water. Page 8
Free-feeding, or waxworms as a staple	A counted schedule and the ridge test. Pages 12 and 14
Two frogs of different sizes together	Size-matched groups only. Page 19
Soap, lotion or sanitizer on the hands	Plain water or wetted gloves. Page 15
A tall enclosure left bare	Dense planting and broad perches high up. Page 10
A water dish deep enough to swim in	Shallower than the frog sits tall
A heat source the frog can touch, or UVB over glass	Everything outside, over mesh. Pages 6 and 9
Cleaning with household products	Plain hot water. Page 11
Skipping quarantine for a new frog	Six to eight weeks apart. Page 18

What the research says

No enrichment study exists for this species. The closest and most useful one is on red-eyed tree frogs, another arboreal tree frog: Michaels, Antwis and Preziosi (2014) found that providing plants affected **body size, growth rate and the bacterial communities on the skin**, and the frogs showed a strong preference for planted areas over bare ones. That is a fitness result rather than an observer scoring activity, which is rare for amphibians: a 2014 review of the whole topic found only fourteen relevant primary research papers. Skin bacteria matter because they are part of how a frog defends itself against pathogens, chytrid included.

Priority order

- ☐ 1. Dense planting at several heights
- ☐ 2. Broad perches near the top of the enclosure
- ☐ 3. Humidity with real drying cycles, and treated water
- ☐ 4. Prey released into cover, not presented
- ☐ 5. Varying where and when food appears
- ☐ 6. Same-size company, if you want a group
- ☐ 7. Novelty, last, and gently

MOVE THE FOOD

An ambush feeder will happily sit in one spot and be fed the same way forever. Release insects into the planting at night and vary where they go in. In dart frogs, simply changing the position of the food dish increased activity, which for an animal this sedentary is a real result from a free change, and more movement is part of the obesity fix on page 21.

Choosing a frog, quarantine & the law

The healthiest frog is chosen well, moved gently and kept apart until it has proved itself.

Choosing one

Buy captive-bred. It is widely available, and wild-caught frogs often carry parasites and disease and adjust less well to captivity. A standard animal runs \$20 to \$60. Blue and other designer colors cost more, but a bluish frog in a store is not proof of a blue morph: the green comes from blue pigment under a yellow layer, the shade shifts, and a frog at a morph price should come from a breeder who can say what its parents were.

Pass on any frog showing listlessness, weight loss, cloudy eyes, skin discoloration or redness on the belly and legs, swelling, labored breathing, or loose stools. Ask what it has been eating and when it last ate, and watch it take an insect if you can.

Bringing it home

STEP	HOW
Move it in a container	A small clear container, never a net, so the frog is never forced through mesh. A ventilated tub with a moist paper towel works for the trip home
Temperature first	Let the container sit beside the new setup until both read the same before the frog moves across. A fast temperature swing is one of the most common ways a new arrival gets stressed
Then leave it alone	Lights, gradient and humidity cycle running for a few days before it arrives; no handling until quarantine ends

Quarantine: six to eight weeks

A new amphibian is kept apart for **6 to 8 weeks**, the usual period. The shortest in use is 30 days, and 60 is preferred. Use its own tub or enclosure with paper towel substrate, its own spray bottle, dish and tools, in a different room if you can, and look after the established frogs first and the new one last. **If it shows any illness partway through, the clock resets** rather than pausing.

Use the window for a first vet exam: a fecal test for parasites and, ideally, a skin swab test for chytrid, the fungus that causes chytridiomycosis. Chytrid is the reason quarantine is close to mandatory for amphibians: the pet trade is a documented route by which an amphibian chytrid fungus has already spread between continents.

NEVER RELEASE A FROG OUTDOORS

Not a healthy one, not an unwanted one. A captive frog carrying a pathogen becomes a wild exposure event the moment it is loose. A frog you cannot keep goes back to a breeder, a rescue or a reptile and amphibian society.

Where it is legal

No state-by-state review of this species has been done for this package, so it carries no state table. Check before you buy. Rules for nonnative amphibians run from wide open to closed: Nevada's list clears all nonindigenous amphibians except bullfrogs, and Oklahoma exempts nonindigenous reptiles and amphibians from its import permits. At the other end, Hawaii allows an animal only if it appears on its approved lists and bars anything never written down, Massachusetts runs a closed list of exempt species, and the District of Columbia's list of allowed animals names no amphibian at all. Your state wildlife agency is the answer that counts, and a city can be stricter than its state.

Group housing by size, sexing & breeding

They tolerate company well. The one rule is not optional.

EVERY FROG IN A GROUP IS A SIMILAR SIZE

A White's tree frog will attempt to swallow anything it can fit in its mouth, including a smaller frog. A mixed-size group is a feeding accident waiting to happen. Juveniles grow at different rates, so a group that started matched needs checking as it grows.

Setting up a group

- **Space:** 24×18×24 in (61×46×61 cm) for two to four frogs of a similar size, against 18×18×24 in for one.
- **Cover:** enough planting and cork that each frog can be out of the others' line of sight, and enough high perches that nobody is pushed to the floor.
- **Feeding:** forceps feeding lets you see that each frog eats its share, so a dominant eater does not get fat while a shy one thins out. Check every frog against the ridge test on page 14, not just the group.
- **A new frog** goes through quarantine before it meets the group, page 18. If one frog falls ill, it comes out to its own tub until the vet has seen it.

Sexing an adult

Most frogs for sale are juveniles, and a juvenile usually cannot be sexed: the adult features may not have appeared yet, and the species takes about two years to mature.

	MALE	FEMALE
Throat	Grayish, wrinkled vocal sac	Plain white
Size	Slimmer and smaller, about 3 in (7.5 cm)	About 4 in (10 cm)
Thumbs	A dark nuptial pad at the base of each thumb in breeding condition	None
Voice	Calls, and calls through the year	Quiet

What happens if a pair breeds

A male and female kept together can breed. In captivity breeding follows the wet season the frogs get in the wild, and keepers who want eggs trigger it by imitating heavy summer rain. The male grips the female from behind in amplexus, which can last for days, and she lays **150 to 300 eggs** in still water. Hatching starts 28 to 36 hours after laying.

The tadpoles are the long part. In good conditions some finish metamorphosis in 2 to 3 weeks, most are out of the water within 2 months, and a few stay tadpoles for up to a year. The froglets then take about two years to reach breeding age. That is hundreds of animals needing homes, food and space.

COMPANY WITHOUT THE PROJECT

Keep two of the same sex. Because juveniles are hard to sex, that usually means buying adults whose throats show which is which. Two males will call; two females are the quiet option.

Health red flags & finding a vet

Hardy for an amphibian, but amphibian illness moves fast, and treatment options narrow the longer it waits.

CALL A VET TODAY IF

The frog is lethargic and losing weight, especially if it is new or has been near a new animal. The belly or legs show redness or pinpoint bleeding. Skin is coming away in patches, or there is excess mucus. It cannot turn itself upright, or the body or limbs are swollen. Breathing is labored. It has been exposed to a cleaner, spray or pesticide. The jaw looks misshapen, a leg is bent, or it twitches or cramps after moving.

BOOK THIS WEEK IF

The eyes look cloudy. The eardrum ridges are folding over. It has refused food with the temperature and humidity confirmed in range. Shed skin is lying uneaten. Stools have been loose, or absent, for longer than its normal pattern. The nose is scraped from rubbing on the glass.

Finding the right vet

Not every exotic vet sees amphibians, and amphibian medicine has real limits, which makes the vet you choose matter. The Association of Reptile and Amphibian Veterinarians runs a find-a-vet directory. Call ahead and ask whether the practice treats frogs, and whether it can run a skin swab for chytrid. An exam typically costs **\$50 to \$150**, and an exotic emergency visit fee alone often starts around **\$250** before treatment. Annual exams are recommended for exotic pets, and one during quarantine catches what arrived with the frog.

Getting the frog there

A well-ventilated plastic container with a moistened paper towel on the bottom, the lid covered or closed, kept at a steady temperature and out of the sun. The full transport routine is on page 34.

What to bring

BRING	WHY
A water sample	From the dish, in its own clean container. The frog never travels in it
Your readings	Temperatures at both ends, the humidity cycle, and the light setup and tube age
Photos of the enclosure	The vet is assessing husbandry as much as the frog
The owner log	Diet and feeding counts, appetite, ridge readings, any new animal or recent loss, and any medication or disinfectant used. Page 36

DO NOTHING CLEVER BEFORE THE APPOINTMENT

No home remedies, no salt baths, no medication. Treatment figures written for other amphibians do not transfer to a frog without a vet confirming them. Keep the frog warm within its range, in a clean tub with treated water, and get it seen.

Obesity, fatty eyes & fatty liver

The defining health risk for the species, and the one entirely in the keeper's hands.

Obesity shows up in this species more than in almost any other pet frog, driven by the same enthusiastic appetite that makes it so satisfying to feed. It is the most common problem in captive adults, and unlike most of this section it is fixed at home.

OBESITY

Cause	Overfeeding, and fatty feeders in particular: waxworms and superworms as anything more than a weekly treat, free-feeding, and a bare enclosure that gives a sedentary frog no reason to move. Many amphibians keep eating as long as prey is available, so the frog will not stop on its own
Signs	Fat bulging visibly over the tympanum, the ridges above it sagging or folding over, and fat building in the armpits. General roundness is not the sign: a moderate shoulder roll is normal for this frog
Response	The ridge test on page 14, then a diet change at home: fewer insects per sitting, fatty items cut out, and more planting and height to climb through
Recovery	Slow and steady, judged monthly on the ridges and photos rather than by the week. Once ridges read defined, go back to the normal adult schedule on page 12, not the old one

FATTY EYES

CORNEAL LIPIDOSIS

Cause	Cholesterol and lipid deposited in the cornea, from a diet too high in fat
Signs	A cloudy look to the eyes, or whitish plaques on them. In an obese frog, fat in the crests above the eyes can also start to block its vision
Diagnosis	A vet exam. Cloudy eyes have other causes too, including the corneal swelling of a bacterial infection on page 23, which is a far more urgent problem
Recovery	Treatment is largely ineffective, but correcting the diet may stop it getting worse. That is the strongest argument for catching weight gain at the ridge stage

FATTY LIVER

HEPATIC LIPIDOSIS

Cause	Sustained obesity raises the risk of this serious fatty liver condition
Signs	An obese frog that also looks enlarged through the body from fat laid down inside it, loses its appetite, or becomes lethargic
Response	A vet visit. Advanced cases with liver involvement are past a home diet fix
Recovery	Depends on how far it has gone, which is why the monthly ridge check exists

THE WHOLE PREVENTION PLAN, IN ONE LINE

Adults 2 to 3 times a week, 3 to 4 insects, waxworms once a week at most, a dense tall enclosure, and a look at the eardrum ridges every month.

Chytridiomycosis

The fungal disease behind amphibian declines worldwide. In a pet, an emergency that quarantine prevents.

Chytridiomycosis is caused by the chytrid fungus *Batrachochytrium dendrobatidis*, Bd for short. It is known to affect hundreds of amphibian species, frogs, toads and salamanders alike, and has been linked to wild population declines going back to the 1970s. It infects the skin, the organ a frog drinks and partly breathes through.

CHYTRID

Cause	Bd, carried in by an infected or contaminated animal, its water, or equipment that touched either. A new frog that skipped quarantine is the usual route
Signs	Lethargy and weight loss. Brown to red discoloration of the skin, and reddening of the belly that can look like red-leg. Excessive skin shedding and excess mucus. Swelling, abnormal posture, incoordination, and losing the ability to turn upright. Sudden death can be the only sign
Diagnosis	A real-time PCR (polymerase chain reaction) test on a swab of the skin, a lab test that detects the fungus's DNA (deoxyribonucleic acid, the genetic code). It is rapid and it is the test to ask for. A skin scraping under the microscope can show the organism, but it is not always seen
Treatment	Vet-prescribed antifungal baths, typically itraconazole daily for about 10 to 11 days. Keeping the frog at the warm end of its range, as the vet directs, may help halt the infection
Recovery	If it is diagnosed early, treatment can be effective. The vet decides on retesting. Everything the frog touched is disinfected or replaced, and the frog stays apart from any others until cleared

IF YOU SUSPECT IT

Isolate the frog at once in a clean tub with paper towel and treated water, wash your hands, use separate tools, and call the vet the same day. Do not wait to see if it eats. Do not move any water, plants or decor from that enclosure into another. Keep the frog in its normal range, within the 70 to 85°F (21 to 29°C) gradient, until the vet sets a treatment temperature.

Prevention is the real defense

- **Quarantine every new amphibian for 6 to 8 weeks**, page 18, and ask for a chytrid swab during it. Treatment options are limited once the disease takes hold.
- **Never share water, plants or tools** between enclosures without disinfecting them.
- **Buy captive-bred**, from a seller who quarantines.
- **Never release a frog**, and never dump enclosure water outdoors where wild amphibians live.

THE SHED CONNECTION

Frogs shed their skin every few days, and shedding helps clear skin microbes. In chytrid-infected frogs, heavier infections go with faster sloughing. So a frog suddenly shedding far more often than usual, or with shed skin lying uneaten, is a reason to book a swab.

Red-leg syndrome & bacterial infection

Usually traced back to a dirty or poorly ventilated enclosure, exactly the kind of thing an owner controls.

RED-LEG	BACTERIAL DERMATOSEPTICEMIA
Cause	Bacteria, typically <i>Aeromonas</i> , with <i>Pseudomonas</i> , <i>Klebsiella</i> , <i>Citrobacter</i> and others also found. These live in the environment and take hold in a frog stressed by dirty water, a stale dish, constant high humidity and poor ventilation
Signs	A red flush on the pale skin of the legs and belly, progressing to pinpoint bleeding under the skin and red-purple patches. Lethargy, loss of appetite, emaciation, skin ulcers. Cloudy eyes can come with it, from corneal swelling
Diagnosis	A vet takes blood, or fluid from the body cavity if there is any, for culture, so the antibiotic is matched to the bacteria. Chytrid can look similar and may be tested for at the same visit
Treatment	Aggressive and immediate: antibiotics chosen by the culture, often with antifungals and fluids. A full review of the enclosure goes with it
Recovery	Guarded. Even with early, aggressive treatment the likelihood of death is high, which is why prevention and a same-day call matter. A frog that recovers goes back into a setup that has been fixed, not the one that made it sick

RED ON THE BELLY OR LEGS IS A SAME-DAY CALL

Isolate the frog in a clean tub with treated water and paper towel, keep it at its normal temperature, and phone the vet. Do not try antibiotics or salt at home.

Bacterial and skin infections

Cause	Enclosures kept too humid without adequate ventilation, or a water dish that is not cleaned often enough. A scraped nose or a wound gives bacteria a way in
Signs	Discolored or reddened patches, sores, excess mucus, swelling, a frog that is dull and off its food. Shed skin left uneaten can be an early hint
Diagnosis	Always a vet when signs appear: skin infections in frogs can be bacterial or fungal, and the treatment differs
Recovery	The real fix is usually in the setup itself: humidity that dips on page 7, a dish emptied daily on page 8, and ventilation that is never sealed off

THE HUSBANDRY PATTERN BEHIND ALL OF IT

Overfeeding drives obesity. A dirty or under-ventilated enclosure drives red-leg and the other bacterial infections. Skipping quarantine is how chytrid gets in. All three are preventable, and a reliable thermometer and hygrometer catch the humidity drift before it becomes an infection.

Metabolic bone disease & vitamin A

Two nutritional diseases, both prevented by the supplement schedule and the UVB tube.

Metabolic bone disease, also called nutritional secondary hyperparathyroidism, is **frequently observed in captive amphibians**. The frog's body pulls calcium out of its own skeleton to keep its blood level up, and the bones soften and deform.

BONE DISEASE	METABOLIC BONE DISEASE
Cause	Too little calcium and vitamin D3 in the diet, missing or expired UVB, and insects with an inverted calcium to phosphorus ratio: undusted, un-gut-loaded crickets are the classic route
Signs	Early on, twitching or spastic cramping after exertion, and weakness. Later, a misshapen or droopy jaw, broken long bones, a curved spine, bent limbs, bloating, and sometimes a cloacal prolapse (tissue pushed out of the vent, the frog's single rear opening). Advanced cases end in tetany, uncontrolled muscle spasm
Diagnosis	A vet exam and a review of the diet, the supplement routine and the UVB tube's age. Bring the jar and the date the tube went in
Treatment	Correcting the husbandry, plus calcium given by mouth daily for around 30 days at a dose the vet sets, with UVB provided
Recovery	Weeks to months, and permanent deformities may remain. The aim is to stop it progressing

PREVENTION IS CHEAP AND SIMPLE

Gut-load the insects, dust them on schedule (adults about once a week, juveniles about twice), use calcium with D3 if there is no UVB, and replace the UVB tube every 6 to 8 months. Page 13 and page 9.

Vitamin A deficiency: short tongue syndrome

Cause	Too little vitamin A reaching the frog, usually a diet of unsupplemented insects
Signs	Lethargy and wasting, and a frog that strikes at prey and misses because its tongue no longer works properly: the tongue's lining changes and it stops catching
Diagnosis	A vet exam and diet history. The classic story is a frog that is plainly hungry and keeps failing to catch
Recovery	Vet-directed supplementation and a corrected diet. Do not dose vitamin A at home: excess has been suggested to interfere with vitamin D metabolism, so more of everything is not the answer

WHY IT IS EASY TO MISS

A frog with early bone disease still looks round and still eats. The first real clue is often behavior, weakness or a cramp after exertion, rather than appearance. Weak limbs, a droopy jaw or twitching are a vet visit, not a supplement change and a wait.

Skin injuries, chemical exposure & dehydration

Three problems that all start at the skin, and all have a cause in the room.

NOSE RUB		ROSTRAL ABRASION	
Cause	Repeatedly striking or rubbing the snout on glass, screen or any barrier, usually a frog pushing along the bottom of the glass trying to get out, or one with too little cover		
Signs	A scraped, pink or raw snout, sometimes with a sore that does not heal		
Response	A raw snout can become a source of infection, so a sore that is red, swelling or not closing is a vet visit. Remove the cause the same day: a paper strip around the outside base of the glass, more cover, and a check that the gradient and humidity are in range		
Recovery	A minor scrape heals once the rubbing stops. If the frog keeps at it, look for what it is trying to escape: heat, crowding, or a cagemate		
CHEMICALS		TOXIC EXPOSURE	
Cause	Anything absorbed through the skin: disinfectants such as iodine, chlorhexidine and quaternary ammonium, chlorine or ammonia in the water, phenol cleaners, pesticides, cigarette smoke, or residue on a keeper's hands		
Signs	Reddening of the skin, blood spots on the skin, increased mucus, and behavior swinging from hyperactive to lethargic		
Response	Move the frog into fresh, dechlorinated water at its normal temperature, shallow enough to sit in, then call the vet and tell them what it was exposed to. Remove the source, and air the room out		
Recovery	Depends on the chemical and the dose. Everything the frog touched gets rinsed in plain hot water and dried, or replaced		
DEHYDRATION			
Cause	A dry enclosure, an empty or fouled water dish, too much heat, or a frog that escaped into a dry house. Amphibians need moisture to prevent drying out, and a frog loses water through its skin		
Signs	Sunken eyes, color changes, dry to tacky skin and a thick slime coat. Activity and feeding both drop		
Response	A shallow soak in clean, dechlorinated water at the frog's normal temperature, no deeper than it sits. A frog that does not perk up, or one found dry and limp, is an emergency: a vet can give replacement fluids		
Recovery	Mild cases correct with the soak; severe ones need the vet. Either way, find out why: hygrometer, dish, warm end, lid		

BURNS AND FALLS

A heat source the frog can reach will burn it, and the belly skin is thin. Every heat source sits outside the enclosure, page 6. Falls from a sagging branch or a dropped hand cause injuries too: anchor every perch, and handle low over something soft. Any open wound on an amphibian goes to the vet, since the skin is the frog's barrier against infection.

FOUND AN ESCAPED FROG?

Pick it up with wet hands, put it in a container with a damp paper towel and a lid, and give it a shallow soak in treated water at room temperature. If it is dry, tacky or limp, call the vet. Then find how it got out, because it will try the same gap again.

Impaction, parasites & shedding problems

Less common, and still worth recognizing early.

IMPACTION	GASTRIC OVERLOAD AND SWALLOWED SUBSTRATE
Cause	A meal too large or too many insects at once, or fine substrate, small gravel or small bark swallowed along with an insect at feeding time
Signs	Bloating and difficulty breathing after an oversized meal. A frog that stops passing stools and stops eating
Diagnosis and treatment	A vet, who may need anything from a stomach wash to endoscopic or surgical removal. Not a home problem
Prevention	Insects sized to the frog, the counts on page 12, coarse substrate or paper towel, and forceps feeding if a frog keeps taking mouthfuls of the floor
Recovery	Depends on what was blocking and how it was removed. Afterward, smaller prey and a coarse or bare floor
PARASITES	
Cause	Protozoa, nematode worms and lungworms, most often arriving with a new frog, wild-caught stock in particular
Signs	Often none. Weight loss despite eating, loose stools, a frog that is dull or thin
Diagnosis	A fecal exam from a fresh sample. Many amphibians carry some harmless organisms, so the point is to find a load heavy enough to treat, not a zero result
Treatment and recovery	Vet-prescribed. Lungworm is contagious to other amphibians, so an affected frog is kept apart until cleared. A fecal exam in quarantine and at the yearly checkup is the prevention
SHEDDING	
WHEN THE SKIN CYCLE GOES WRONG	
Normal	A full shed about every 2 days at 73 to 91°F (23 to 33°C), every 3 to 4 days cooler, eaten as it comes away. Page 16
Signs	Shed skin lying uneaten in the enclosure, which suggests a frog that has lost its appetite. Or sloughing far more often than usual, which can mean a skin infection, chytrid among them
Response	Book the vet, and take a note of what you saw and when. Do not pull at skin on the frog
Recovery	Follows the underlying cause, which is the reason a shedding change is treated as a symptom rather than a problem in itself
SWELLING	
FLUID SWELLING OF THE BODY OR LIMBS	
Cause	Several serious ones. Chytrid can cause swelling, and so can ranavirus, a viral disease of amphibians that is frequently fatal. Advanced bone disease can bring bloating
Signs	A body or limbs puffed up with fluid. With ranavirus, reddened skin and bleeding under the belly; with chytrid, the skin signs on page 22
Response	A same-day vet call, with the frog isolated in a clean tub, and no water, plants or tools shared with any other enclosure
Recovery	Follows the cause. Ranavirus is frequently fatal; chytrid caught early can respond to treatment. The frog stays apart from any others until the vet clears it

PAPER TOWEL IS A DIAGNOSTIC TOOL

For any frog under watch, swap the substrate for plain paper towel. You can see every stool, every bit of shed skin and every leftover insect, and a vet can be told exactly what came out and when.

Setup checklist & targets

Essential setup checklist

- ☐ 18×18×24 in (46×46×61 cm) arboreal terrarium, locking, with a mesh top. 24×18×24 in for two to four
- ☐ Coarse orchid bark, coco husk or a bioactive soil mix
- ☐ Broad-leaved live plants, artificial foliage for the dense parts
- ☐ Cork bark, PVC (polyvinyl chloride, ordinary plastic) pipe hides, sturdy branches, broad perches mounted high
- ☐ Shallow water dish, shallower than the frog sits tall
- ☐ 5% UVB T5 HO (high output) tube, over mesh, on a timer
- ☐ Low-wattage bulb or side-mounted heat mat, outside, on a thermostat
- ☐ Digital thermometer and hygrometer, read at both ends
- ☐ Water conditioner for chlorine and chloramine
- ☐ A spray bottle that has never held anything but treated water
- ☐ Calcium with D3 and a multivitamin
- ☐ Gut-loaded live feeders, and blunt forceps

Targets

TARGET	°F	°C
Cool side, low	70 to 75	21 to 24
Basking area, high	80 to 85	27 to 29
Night	mid-70s	about 24
Never above, at the warm end	90	32
Never below, anywhere	65	18
Humidity	50 to 60% baseline, misted to 70 to 80% once or twice daily, then a dry-down	
Water	Dechlorinated tap or spring water. Never distilled or RO	
UVB	Basking branch at least 6 in (15 cm) below the tube; replace every 6 to 8 months	
Light cycle	12 hours on, 12 hours off	
Feeding, adult	3 to 4 insects, 2 to 3 times a week; dust about once a week	
Feeding, juvenile	Daily; dust about twice a week	

Before your frog comes home

- ☐ Enclosure running for a few days, with the gradient and the humidity cycle both verified
- ☐ A jug of treated water made up and labeled
- ☐ Quarantine tub ready if other amphibians live in the house
- ☐ A vet that sees frogs found, and a first visit booked inside quarantine
- ☐ Feeder supply and gut-load sorted for the first two weeks
- ☐ Cleaning products moved out of the frog's room

Emergency & quick targets

CALL THE VET NOW IF

Lethargy and weight loss, above all in a new frog. Redness or pinpoint bleeding on the belly or legs. Skin coming away in patches, or excess mucus. Cannot turn itself upright. Swelling of the body or limbs. Labored breathing. Exposure to a cleaner, spray or pesticide. A misshapen jaw, bent limbs, or twitching after moving. Found dry, tacky and limp.

READING	°F	°C
Cool side, low	70 to 75	21 to 24
Basking area, high	80 to 85	27 to 29
Act above, at the warm end	90	32
Act below, anywhere	65	18
Humidity	50 to 60% baseline, 70 to 80% after misting	

WHILE YOU WAIT FOR THE VET

Isolate the frog in a clean tub on damp paper towel, with a shallow dish of dechlorinated water, at its normal temperature. Wash your hands, and use separate tools. No salt, no medication, no home remedies. After a chemical exposure, a shallow soak in fresh treated water first.

Your numbers

Vet who sees frogs _____

UVB tube installed _____

24-hour exotic emergency clinic _____

Last ridge check _____

Frog's name and age _____

Last vet visit _____

Routine, written down

Feeding days _____

Misting times _____

Dusting day _____

Lights on and off at _____

HAVE THIS READY WHEN YOU CALL

What you saw and when it started. Both temperatures and the humidity. When it last ate and how many insects. Any new animal in the house, and any cleaner, spray or new plant near the enclosure. Bring a water sample in its own container, photos of the setup, and the owner log.

Budget: setup & shopping list

United States retail ranges, October 2026, rounded to the nearest \$5. The low end is basic but correct gear; the high end is premium.

INITIAL SETUP	TYPICAL COST
Arboreal terrarium, 18×18×24 in (46×46×61 cm) or larger (check the dimensions before you buy)	\$100 to \$200
Broad-leaved live plants	\$15 to \$35
Artificial foliage for the dense parts	\$10 to \$20
Cork bark and PVC pipe hides	\$15 to \$30
Sturdy climbing branches, mounted high	\$15 to \$30
UVB fixture, a 14 in hood across the 18 in top (check the length against your enclosure), 5% UVB T5 HO tube included	\$45 to \$75
Digital thermometer and hygrometer	\$15 to \$25
Side-mounted heat mat and thermostat (check the mat size against your enclosure)	\$25 to \$40
Coarse orchid bark, coco husk or bioactive soil (check the quantity against the floor)	\$25 to \$40
Shallow water dish	\$5 to \$15
Water conditioner, chlorine and chloramine	\$5 to \$15
Fine mist spray bottle	\$5 to \$15
First supply of calcium with D3 and a multivitamin	\$15 to \$25
Setup subtotal	\$295 to \$565
The frog, standard color, captive-bred	\$20 to \$60
First vet exam	\$50 to \$150
All in, frog home and checked	\$365 to \$775

Highly recommended, not in the total: a UV index meter, about \$240 to \$265, the only way to check the UVB tube's height and when it needs replacing; UV cards do not measure UVB.

A blue or designer color costs more than the standard frog. A second thermometer, if your unit reads one spot, adds a little. A setup quoted at \$200 to \$400 leaves out the heat source, substrate, branches and smaller lines above, which is the difference. A UVB tube's wattage is not its length: a slim high-output tube of 24 watts is about 22 in (56 cm) long, 39 watts about 34 in (86 cm), 54 watts about 46 in (117 cm). Match the length in inches to two-thirds of the enclosure.

Budget: yearly costs

What a White's tree frog costs to keep each year once the setup on the previous page is in place, on the same rounding.

YEARLY ONGOING	TYPICAL COST
Gut-loaded live feeder insects	\$80 to \$150
Supplement top-ups	\$15 to \$20
UVB tube replacement, budgeted every 6 months (two a year)	\$40 to \$45
Water conditioner top-ups	\$15 to \$30
Recurring supplies , about \$10 to \$25 a month	\$150 to \$245
Annual vet exam	\$50 to \$150
Yearly, with the exam	\$200 to \$395

Substrate replacement and a little electricity go on top. Prices move; treat these tables as a snapshot, not a quote.

PLAN FOR, DON'T COUNT ON AVOIDING

An exotic emergency visit fee alone often starts around \$250 before any treatment, and a chytrid or red-leg case means tests, medication and repeat visits. A few hundred dollars set aside matters as much as any line here.

OVER A WHOLE LIFE

At \$200 to \$395 a year over an average of about 16 years, this frog costs roughly \$3,200 to \$6,400 in routine care after setup, before a single emergency. Cheap to buy, long to keep.

First 30 days

The first month sets the habits. Quarantine runs past it, to six to eight weeks.

Day 1

- ☐ Move the frog in a container, matching temperature before it crosses over
- ☐ Photograph it from the side for a ridge baseline, and weigh it in a lidded tub if you have a gram scale
- ☐ Fill in page 28 and the equipment dates on page 37
- ☐ Lights off and leave it alone

Week 1

- ☐ No handling. Evening misting, and check the hygrometer an hour later and the next afternoon
- ☐ Offer the first feeding in the evening once it has settled, and count what is eaten
- ☐ Dish emptied and refilled daily with treated water
- ☐ Watch for normal stools, and note anything odd on page 36

Week 2

- ☐ First vet visit inside quarantine: fecal exam, and ask about a chytrid skin swab
- ☐ Settle the feeding days and the dusting day, and write them on page 28

Week 3

- ☐ Adjust the humidity cycle if it is not dipping back to 50 to 60%
- ☐ Start releasing insects into the planting rather than presenting them
- ☐ Still no handling, and still the established frogs first and this one last

Week 4

- ☐ First monthly ridge check against the day 1 photo, page 14
- ☐ Review the feeding counts. Ridges sagging already means fewer insects
- ☐ Fill in the pet-sitter sheet, page 35, before you need it

Weeks 5 to 8

- ☐ Quarantine continues to 6 to 8 weeks; the clock resets if it shows any illness
- ☐ Act on the fecal result rather than filing it
- ☐ Once quarantine is done and the frog is eating well, first short handling sessions with wet hands, page 15
- ☐ If it is joining others, check sizes match before it goes in, page 19

A QUIET FIRST MONTH IS A GOOD FIRST MONTH

A new frog that hides by day, eats in the evening and sheds out of sight is doing everything right. The things to watch for are the red flags on page 20, not a lack of activity.

Symptom quick reference

SYMPTOM	LIKELY CAUSE	ACTION
Fat folding over the eardrum ridges, armpit fat	Obesity	Cut portions and fatty feeders; more climbing (page 21)
Cloudy eyes or whitish plaques	Corneal lipidosis, or infection	Vet this week; same day if the frog is also dull or red (page 21)
Lethargy and weight loss in a new frog	Chytrid	Isolate, vet today, ask for a skin swab PCR (page 22)
Shedding far more often, excess mucus, skin coming off in patches	Chytrid or skin infection	Isolate, vet today (page 22)
Red flush or pinpoint bleeding on belly and legs	Red-leg, or chytrid	Isolate, vet today; fix the dish and ventilation (page 23)
Sores, discolored patches, swelling	Bacterial or fungal skin infection	Vet; review humidity cycle and dish (page 23)
Twitching or cramping after moving, weak limbs	Early metabolic bone disease	Vet; check the dusting and the UVB tube's age (page 24)
Misshapen jaw, bent limbs, curved spine	Advanced metabolic bone disease	Vet; lower the perches meanwhile (page 24)
Hungry, strikes at insects and misses	Vitamin A deficiency	Vet; do not dose at home (page 24)
Scraped or raw snout	Rubbing on glass	Paper strip and more cover; vet if sore (page 25)
Red skin, blood spots, mucus after a spray or cleaner	Chemical exposure	Shallow soak in treated water, call the vet (page 25)
Sunken eyes, tacky skin, sluggish	Dehydration	Shallow soak; check humidity and dish; vet if no improvement (page 25)
Bloated, breathing hard after a big meal	Gastric overload	Vet; smaller insects from now on (page 26)
No stools and not eating	Impaction, often swallowed substrate	Vet; switch to paper towel (page 26)
Thin despite eating, loose stools	Parasites	Vet with a fresh fecal sample (page 26)
Shed skin lying uneaten	Appetite loss, an early illness sign	Book the vet with notes (page 26)
Body or limbs swollen	Chytrid, ranavirus, others	Isolate, vet today (page 26)
Sitting in the dish day and night	Too warm or too dry	Check both thermometers and the hygrometer (page 8)
Refusing food, setup in range	Early illness	Vet this week (page 20)

Daily, weekly & seasonal routine

Daily

- ☐ Mist in the evening with treated water as the frog wakes
- ☐ Empty, rinse and refill the water dish
- ☐ Spot clean droppings off leaves, branches and glass
- ☐ Glance at both temperatures and the hygrometer
- ☐ Juveniles: feed. Pull leftover insects a few hours later

Two or three times a week

- ☐ Adults: 3 to 4 gut-loaded insects in the evening, and count them
- ☐ Handling, if any: 5 to 15 minutes, twice a week at most

Weekly

- ☐ Dust: adults about once, juveniles about twice
- ☐ Wash bark, moss or paper lining as needed; scrub the dish
- ☐ Check every branch and perch is still anchored

Monthly

- ☐ Ridge check and side photo, logged on page 36
- ☐ Sniff the substrate: replace soil that smells or stays waterlogged
- ☐ Move the feeding spot or a perch for a little novelty

Every 6 to 8 months

- ☐ Replace the UVB tube, even if it still lights

Yearly

- ☐ Wellness exam with a fecal test
- ☐ Supplements past their date replaced

Seasonal

- ☐ Summer: is the enclosure out of the sun? Know how you will keep the warm end under 90°F (32°C)
- ☐ Winter: check the night low against 65°F (18°C), and watch that heating dries the air

WHAT A GOOD WEEK LOOKS LIKE

The hygrometer at 70 to 80% an hour after the evening mist and back to 50 to 60% by the next afternoon. The cool side 70 to 75°F (21 to 24°C), the basking area 80 to 85°F (27 to 29°C). A clean dish every morning. A frog that sleeps high up by day, strikes cleanly at its insects in the evening, and leaves no shed skin lying around.

IF YOU ONLY KEEP ONE HABIT

Count the insects. Overfeeding is this species' most common problem, and it happens one generous handful at a time. A number on the log each feeding day is what turns the ridge test from a surprise into a trend.

Power outages, heat waves, travel & transport

The two edges are 65°F (18°C) and 90°F (32°C). Most of this page is keeping the frog between them, and damp.

When the power goes out

- Put a battery thermometer where the frog sits. Act if it is heading below 65°F (18°C).
- Drape thick towels or a blanket over the enclosure, leaving a vent gap, to hold in the heat that is left.
- Or move the frog in a ventilated tub with damp paper towel to the warmest room, usually one without exterior walls.
- A wrapped hand warmer or hot water bottle beside the tub, **never touching the frog**.
- Keep misting by hand with your stored treated water: the dish and the humidity still matter.
- No candles, gas stove or open flame near the enclosure. Hold off feeding until warmth is back.
- More than a day below 65°F (18°C): board the frog with a vet or a friend who has power.

When it gets too hot

- Turn the heat source off first. In a heat wave the room is the heater.
- Get the enclosure out of any sun and away from exterior walls, to the coolest room in the house.
- More air: uncover the mesh, and run a fan across the room, not into the enclosure.
- Make sure the dish is full of fresh treated water at room temperature, and mist the surfaces.
- A frozen bottle wrapped in a towel can sit beside the enclosure, never inside it.
- Warm end past 90°F (32°C) with a frog that is hyperactive, uncoordinated or lethargic, the signs of overheating: cool the room, give it fresh treated water at room temperature, and call the vet.

Leaving town

TRIP	ADULT	JUVENILE
1 to 2 nights	A sitter daily for the dish, the evening mist and a temperature check. Lights and heat on timers and a thermostat	A sitter daily, with pre-counted insects
3 to 7 nights	A sitter daily, with written feeding days and counts	A sitter daily
Over a week	A daily sitter who has done a practice visit with you, or boarding with a vet who sees amphibians. Never general dog and cat boarding	

One tier stricter than a desert reptile, because the misting and the dish are daily jobs. The hand mister and treated water are what sitters most often get wrong: leave the jug labeled.

Transport and vet trips

- A clean, well-ventilated plastic container with a moistened paper towel on the bottom and the lid on. No loose substrate and no water dish to slosh.
- Set it inside a dark bag, box or small cooler to hold the temperature steady and keep the view calm.
- In cold weather warm the car first, and on a trip of more than about 30 minutes below 65°F (18°C) add a wrapped hand warmer beside the container, not touching it. In hot weather cool the car first and keep the container out of the sun.
- Never leave the frog in a parked car, hot or cold. Check it at stops rather than only on arrival.

OUTAGE KIT, PACKED BEFORE YOU NEED IT

Two hand warmers or a hot water bottle, two thick towels, a battery thermometer, a ventilated tub with paper towel, a full jug of treated water, and the vet and emergency clinic numbers on paper, not only in a phone that might die.

FILL IN AND LEAVE BY THE ENCLOSURE

Pet-sitter sheet

Everything a sitter needs on one page. Walk them through it once in person before the first solo visit.

Frog's name _____

Age and normal look _____

My phone _____

Vet who sees frogs _____

24-hour emergency clinic _____

Backup contact _____

Each visit

- ☐ Empty, rinse and refill the water dish from the labeled jug of treated water. Never straight from the faucet
- ☐ In the evening, mist the leaves and glass from the frog's own spray bottle until they bead
- ☐ Read both thermometers and the hygrometer, and write them down
- ☐ On feeding days, release the counted insects in the evening; pull any still loose a few hours later
- ☐ Wipe droppings off the glass and leaves with plain water
- ☐ Wash your hands with soap after, away from the frog. Nothing gets rinsed in the kitchen sink

Feeding while I'm away

Feeding days _____

How many insects _____

Dusting day _____

Where everything is kept _____

Normal readings

Cool side, low	70 to 75°F (21 to 24°C)
Basking area, high	80 to 85°F (27 to 29°C)
Humidity	70 to 80% after misting, 50 to 60% the rest of the time

Please don't

- Pick the frog up. If it must be moved, wet your hands with treated water first, and never with soap, lotion or sanitizer on them.
- Spray any cleaner, air freshener or bug spray in this room, or use one on anything in the enclosure.
- Change any dial, timer or thermostat, or move the enclosure into a sunny spot. Feed anything not on this sheet, or extra because it looks hungry: it always looks hungry.

CALL ME IF

Any temperature reads under 65°F (18°C) or the warm end over 90°F (32°C). The belly or legs look red. Skin is peeling in patches, or the frog is covered in slime. It is limp, cannot turn itself over, or is swollen. It has escaped. If I don't answer, call the vet number above.

Owner log

One row a week. Photocopy this page, or track digitally. Consistency matters more than the format.

DATE	INSECTS THIS WEEK	DUSTED	WARM / COOL °F	HUMIDITY HIGH / LOW	RIDGES	STOOLS	NOTES

Ridges: write **U** for none visible (underweight), **OK** for defined, **O** for sagging or folding (obese). Humidity: the reading an hour after the evening mist, and the next afternoon's.

WHY BOTHER LOGGING

For this frog, the feeding count and the ridge reading are the early warning system. A frog drifting toward obesity shows up as a column of generous numbers weeks before it shows up as fat over the eardrum. Sixteen rows is four months, long enough to see a real trend rather than a bad week, and it is the first thing a vet will want to see.

Equipment & vet log

Equipment log

ITEM	INSTALLED OR OPENED	REPLACE OR CHECK BY	DONE
UVB tube (replace every 6 to 8 months)			
Thermostat (check against a thermometer monthly)			
Thermometer and hygrometer batteries			
Substrate (soil when it smells or stays waterlogged)			
Calcium and multivitamin (replace when out of date)			
Water conditioner			

Twelve-month planner

Tick the box in the month you did it. M1 is whichever month you start in, M12 the last.

TASK	M1	M2	M3	M4	M5	M6	M7	M8	M9	M10	M11	M12
Ridge check and photo	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Substrate checked or changed	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Perches checked for anchoring	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
UVB tube	☐						☐					
Vet exam and fecal test	☐											☐

The UVB row is ticked at 6 months here; move it to month 8 if your tube's maker allows the longer interval.

Vet visit log

DATE	REASON	FINDINGS AND TESTS	TREATMENT, FOLLOW-UP

Quarantine record

Arrived _____
From _____

Fecal and chytrid results _____
Cleared on _____

Glossary, A to H

Amplexus	The mating grip, a male holding a female from behind. In this species it can last for days. Page 19.
Arboreal	Tree-dwelling. Why the enclosure is measured in height and the best perches go near the top.
Bd	<i>Batrachochytrium dendrobatidis</i> , the chytrid fungus behind chytridiomycosis. Page 22.
Bioactive	A living, planted substrate that breaks down waste. An option for the floor of the enclosure.
Carotenoids	Pigment compounds amphibians cannot make for themselves, one reason a multivitamin is part of the diet.
Chloramine	A tap water disinfectant that does not leave water on standing. Needs a conditioner to split it. Page 8.
Cloacal prolapse	Tissue pushed out through the vent, the frog's single rear opening. A sign of advanced bone disease. Page 24.
Coelom	The body cavity. In an obese frog it looks enlarged from the fat laid down inside it.
Corneal lipidosis	Cholesterol and fat deposited in the cornea, seen as cloudy eyes. Page 21.
D3, vitamin D3	The form of vitamin D a frog makes in its skin under UVB light and needs in order to use the calcium in its food. Pages 9, 13.
Dechlorinator	A water conditioner that neutralizes chlorine and chloramine. Everything that touches the frog goes through one.
Dermatosepticemia	A bacterial infection of the skin that has spread into the blood. Red-leg is the common form.
DNA	Deoxyribonucleic acid, the genetic code in every cell. The chytrid test looks for the fungus's DNA. Page 22.
Gut-loading	Feeding the insects a calcium-rich diet for 24 to 72 hours before they go to the frog. Page 13.
Hepatic lipidosis	Fatty liver disease, the serious end of obesity.
Hygrometer	A humidity meter, read mid-height to track the humidity cycle. Page 7.

Glossary, I to Z

IUCN	The International Union for Conservation of Nature, whose Red List rates this species Least Concern.
Metabolic bone disease	Softened, deformed bones from too little calcium, vitamin D3 or UVB. Page 24.
Nocturnal	Active at night. Why misting, feeding and health checks happen in the evening.
Nuptial pad	The dark pad at the base of a breeding male's thumb, used to grip a female.
PCR swab	PCR, polymerase chain reaction, is a lab test that finds DNA. On a skin swab it detects the chytrid fungus. Page 22.
PVC	Polyvinyl chloride, the ordinary rigid plastic used for plumbing pipe, cut into tube hides. Page 29.
Quarantine	Keeping a new frog apart for 6 to 8 weeks before it shares space or tools with any other amphibian. Page 18.
Ranavirus	A viral disease of amphibians causing swelling and bleeding under the skin, frequently fatal. Page 26.
Red-leg	A bacterial infection, typically <i>Aeromonas</i> , named for the redness on the legs and belly. Page 23.
Rostral abrasion	A snout scraped raw from rubbing on glass or screen. Page 25.
RO water	Reverse-osmosis water: filtered so far that almost nothing is dissolved in it. Never used for a frog without remineralizing. Page 8.
Short tongue syndrome	A tongue that no longer catches prey, from vitamin A deficiency. Page 24.
Slough	The outer skin a frog sheds every few days and eats. Page 16.
T5 HO	T5 high output: a slim fluorescent tube 5/8 inch across, the usual UVB source. The percentage on the box is its UVB output, and 5% keeps it gentle. Page 9.
Tetany	Uncontrolled muscle spasm, the advanced stage of metabolic bone disease.
Tympanum	The round external eardrum behind the eye. The fat ridge above it is the body condition check. Page 14.
UVB	Ultraviolet B, the band of ultraviolet light a frog uses to make vitamin D3, which it needs to use calcium. Page 9.
UV index (UVI)	UV is ultraviolet, the invisible light that includes UVB. The UV index (UVI) measures UVB strength at a point. Roughly 0.7 to 1.6 where this frog basks. Page 9.
Vocal sac	The stretchy throat skin a male calls with: grayish and wrinkled on a male, plain white on a female.

Sources

Where the numbers in this package come from, so you can check them yourself.

Veterinary references for this species

- Dr. Gregory Rich, Avian and Exotic Animal Hospital of Louisiana: White's Tree Frog Care Sheet. The ridge test, feeding by frog size, the 12 hour light cycle, heat outside the enclosure, aged and conditioned water, cleaning with plain hot water, the bark and paper-strip furnishing tips.
- Dr. Michaela Betts, Exotics Keeper Magazine: A Vet's Care Guide for White's Tree Frogs. Feeding and dusting frequency by age, the clinical signs of obesity, a UV index of 0.7 to 1.6, signs of chytrid and red-leg, quarantine and chytrid testing.
- Chicago Exotics Animal Hospital: White's Tree Frog Care. The 90°F (32°C) basking ceiling and 65°F (18°C) night floor, dish depth, the froglet feeding row, and the warning signs of illness.
- Tree of Life Exotic Pet Medical Center: White's Tree Frog Care. Light cycle, humidity with drying periods, gloves, and the conservative 10 to 15-plus year lifespan.
- VCA Animal Hospitals (originally Veterinary Centers of America): Frogs as Pets. Adult size, and this species as one of the few frogs suited to handling.

Amphibian medicine and husbandry

- Merck Veterinary Manual: Infectious Diseases of Amphibians. Chytrid signs, PCR diagnosis, itraconazole baths and warmth as part of treatment; red-leg organisms, signs and culture; ranavirus.
- Merck Veterinary Manual: Noninfectious Disorders of Amphibians. Metabolic bone disease signs and treatment, vitamin A deficiency, obesity, corneal lipidosis, rostral abrasions.
- Merck Veterinary Manual: Environment and Husbandry for Amphibians. Ventilation, water free of chlorine and chloramine, UVB replacement at 6 to 8 months and glass blocking UVB, cedar and pine mulch, the 6 to 8 week quarantine, bleach disinfection, carotenoids.
- Merck Veterinary Manual: Clinical Techniques in Amphibians. Transport container, what to bring to the vet, moistened gloves.
- Dr. Douglas Mader, Reptiles Magazine: How to Recognize and Prevent Medical Ailments in Amphibians. Signs and response for dehydration, overheating, toxic exposure, gastric overload, corneal lipidosis, red-leg prognosis and parasites.
- LafeberVet, McDermott and Pollock: Amphibian Handling and Restraint. Moistened gloves, minimizing handling, glove-type cautions.
- Cramp and colleagues (2014), Conservation Physiology, and Ohmer and colleagues (2017), Scientific Reports. Skin sloughing intervals and the link between faster sloughing and chytrid load.
- Michaels, Antwis and Preziosi (2014), PLoS ONE: plant cover and fitness in red-eyed tree frogs. Hurme and colleagues: enrichment for dendrobatid frogs.
- Centers for Disease Control and Prevention: Reptiles and Amphibians. *Salmonella* and the under-5 rule.
- Smithsonian's National Zoo and Animal Diversity Web, University of Michigan: lifespan, clutch size, hatching and maturity.
- Association of Reptile and Amphibian Veterinarians: find-a-vet directory.
- Zoo Med Laboratories: the ReptiSun 5.0 and 10.0 UVB T5 HO product pages. Tube lengths and wattages.

REFERENCE

Where the sources disagree

Where credible sources give different numbers, this package prints one and says why.

TOPIC	WHAT THE SOURCES SAY	WHAT THIS PACKAGE USES
Night temperature	Mid-70s°F; 72 to 78°F; 70 to 72°F; 64 to 70°F (18 to 21°C); and "not below 65°F"	Mid-70s°F as the target, 65°F (18°C) as the floor
Basking	80 to 85°F; 82 to 85°F; a gradient of 80 to 86°F; not above 90°F; one vet guide gives a 95°F (35°C) spot	80 to 85°F, with 90°F (32°C) as the ceiling. The 95°F figure is the outlier
Humidity	50 to 60%; 50 to 70% with drying periods; 60 to 70%	50 to 60% baseline, misted to 70 to 80%, then a dry-down. Every source agrees on the drying
Adult feeding	2 to 3 times a week; every 2 to 3 days; twice a week; 3 to 4 times a week	2 to 3 times a week, corrected by the ridge test
Dusting	Adults weekly, juveniles twice weekly; daily for very young frogs; calcium 2 to 3 times and a multivitamin weekly; 3 to 4 times weekly	Weekly for adults, twice weekly for juveniles. The frog's condition and the vet adjust it
Enclosure	15-gallon tall; 20-gallon tall; 25-gallon; 18×18×24 in	18×18×24 in (46×46×61 cm), the largest common minimum
Size, lifespan	3 to 4.5 in, 3 to 5 in, 4 to 5 in; 10 to 15-plus years, 15 to 20, about 16 on average with a record of 21	3 to 4.5 in (7 to 11 cm); about 16 years, plan for well over a decade
Quarantine	6 to 8 weeks (veterinary); 30 days minimum, 60 preferred (zoo practice); 60 to 90 days for higher-risk frogs	6 to 8 weeks, longer for a wild-caught or sick frog
Gloves	Powder-free nitrile; moistened vinyl; toxicity reported in tadpoles from latex, nitrile and to a lesser extent vinyl	Powder-free vinyl, nitrile second, never latex, wetted. The froglet caution is on page 15

Version history & about

What changed in each edition, so a printed copy can be placed.

Version history

This is edition 1.1 (Oct 2026). The store page shows the current edition; re-download free if yours is older. Where this list and a page disagree, the page wins.

- **1.1, Oct 2026.** Aligned to the current layout: cover icon, section order, page pointers, a units note, the thermostat probe mounting and a longer glossary, 42 pages. Costs: every item priced and rounded to the nearest \$5; setup \$295 to \$565, yearly \$150 to \$245 in supplies. Other changes are wording only.
- **1.0, Oct 2026.** First edition, 39 pages.

This package is a husbandry reference compiled from the sources on page 40 and cross-checked against current veterinary guidance at the time of publication. It is not a substitute for a veterinarian who sees amphibians, and nothing in it should delay a vet visit. Treatments described here are for recognizing what a vet may do, not for use at home.

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